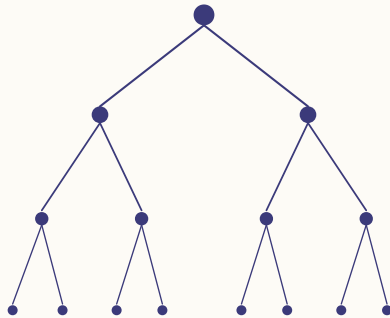


BOOK SUMMARY



Multipliers

How the Best Leaders Make Everyone Smarter

LIZ WISEMAN

2010

What This Book Is About

Structurally, the book is built around five paired chapters, each naming one discipline practiced by "Multiplier" leaders and setting it directly against its opposite, a "Diminisher" pattern — bookended by an opening chapter that introduces the whole framework and a closing chapter on how to shift your own default mode. It draws on a research study of leaders across dozens of organisations, comparing how much of their people's intelligence and capability each style actually accessed.

What it is not: this is not a book about being a nicer or more encouraging boss. Wiseman is explicit that some Diminishers are well-meaning and even beloved — "Accidental Diminishers" who believe they're helping — and that some Multipliers are demanding and intense. The distinction the book draws is not warmth versus harshness; it is whether a leader's presence expands or shrinks the intelligence of the people around them.

The message, stated plainly: **Multiplier leaders get significantly more capability out of the same people than Diminisher leaders do**, not through motivation tricks, but through five specific, learnable disciplines of how they use their attention, their questions, and their control.

The Woman Behind It

Wiseman spent close to two decades at Oracle, most of it running the company's internal leadership development function, including its corporate university — meaning her material comes directly from watching thousands of managers operate inside one large organisation, not from an outside academic study of leadership in the abstract. She holds a business degree, but the book's real foundation is that internal, practitioner's vantage point.

After leaving Oracle, she founded a research and executive advisory firm, and the book itself grew out of formal research this firm conducted — structured interviews and data collection across a wide range of leaders, rather than a single company's internal experience alone.

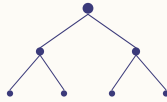
She does not present the book as an academic psychology text; its authority rests on the research study behind it and her own years directly managing leadership development, not on a claim to be a trained organisational psychologist.

Beyond this book, she is known for a later expanded edition and for continued writing and speaking on leadership and organisational capability, building on the same Multiplier framework.

Where This Book Came From

Published in 2010, the book emerged from a specific, pointed question Wiseman kept encountering after leaving Oracle: why did some leaders seem to get so much more out of the exact same people than others did? She had seen both types up close inside a large company, and the book is the product of turning that observation into a formal, multi-year research study across a wide range of organisations and leaders.

She was reacting against a leadership culture that treats intelligence and talent as fixed and mostly a matter of who you hire — arguing instead that how a leader behaves can access, or shut off, capability that was already present in their people all along.



Seven chapters, one leadership question, argued from five different disciplines.

Some leaders drain the intelligence and capability out of the people around them, while others amplify it — the difference isn't raw talent, it's a specific, learnable set of practices that get more out of people than they knew they had.

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The Multiplier Effect

Multiplier leaders access almost all of a person's intelligence and capability; Diminisher leaders access only a fraction of it.

Wiseman opens with the observation that launched the whole study: she had worked for two bosses at the same company, with the same title, managing similarly talented people — and one of them left her feeling brilliant and capable, while the other left her feeling smaller and less capable than she knew she was. Same person, same skills, wildly different amount of intelligence actually being used.

She names the two types plainly: **Multipliers are the kind of leaders who use their intelligence to amplify the smarts and capabilities of the people around them; Diminishers are absorbed in their own intelligence, stifle others, and end up creating a resource-drained organisation.** Crucially, most Diminishers don't see themselves that way — many are "Accidental Diminishers," well-intentioned managers whose habits shut people down without their realising it.

2x

Roughly how much more capability Wiseman's research found Multipliers get out of the same people, compared with Diminishers

The rest of the book is organised around five specific disciplines that separate the two types — not personality traits, but repeatable practices anyone can learn and adopt.

WHAT THE AUTHOR WANTS YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Notice, rather than act: before anything else, Wiseman wants you to recall your own experience of working for each type of leader, and to honestly ask which one you currently resemble more — including the possibility that you're an Accidental Diminisher without realising it.

The Talent Magnet

Talent Magnets attract talented people and use them to their fullest; Empire Builders hoard resources and underutilise the people they have.

Talent Magnets, Wiseman writes, are known for finding and attracting talented people, and, more importantly, for deploying them at their highest point of contribution — finding what she calls a person's "native genius," the thing they do so easily and naturally that they don't even think of it as a skill. Empire Builders do the opposite: they hoard talented people and resources under their own control, often leaving capable people underused or parked, because a bigger team, even an underutilised one, looks like more power.

TALENT MAGNET	EMPIRE BUILDER
<i>finds native genius</i>	<i>hoards resources</i>
<i>uses people fully</i>	<i>underutilises them</i>
<i>lets people move on</i>	<i>blocks their growth</i>

WHAT EACH DOES WITH TALENT, ONCE THEY HAVE IT

A Talent Magnet is also willing to let people move on — to a bigger role elsewhere, even outside the organisation — because attracting talent matters more to them than possessing it. Empire Builders, by contrast, tend to block people's growth or mobility, because losing a talented person feels like losing territory.

WHAT THE AUTHOR WANTS YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Wiseman's prescription: identify each person's native genius — what they do so naturally it doesn't feel like effort to them — and

deliberately place them there, even if it means giving up direct control over that person's time or output.

The Liberator

Liberators create an intense environment that demands people's best thinking; Tyrants create a tense environment that suppresses it.

Liberators, Wiseman argues, create space — they invite other people's best ideas, hold high standards, and are comfortable admitting their own mistakes, which frees others to take risks and speak up. Tyrants create the opposite atmosphere: one dominated by their own opinion, where mistakes are punished and people learn to stay quiet rather than offer a half-formed idea that might be shot down.

LIBERATOR	TYRANT
<i>creates space to think</i>	<i>dominates the room</i>
<i>admits own mistakes</i>	<i>punishes mistakes</i>
<i>demands best thinking</i>	<i>shuts thinking down</i>

THE ATMOSPHERE EACH STYLE CREATES IN A ROOM

The Liberator's environment is not soft — Wiseman is explicit that it is intense and holds people to a high bar. The difference from a Tyrant is not the level of demand, but whether that demand is paired with genuine space to fail, think, and speak, or with fear that shuts those things down.

WHAT THE AUTHOR WANTS YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Wiseman wants you to notice whether people in your meetings offer their real, unfinished thinking or only safe, pre-approved answers — and to deliberately create space for the former, including by naming your own mistakes first.

The Challenger

Challengers extend a challenge that stretches people's thinking; Know-It-Alls hand out answers and directives instead.

Challengers, in Wiseman's account, don't need to be the smartest person in the room, and don't try to prove it. Instead, they seed opportunities by posing a hard question or an ambitious possibility, and then let others figure out how to get there — building both understanding and confidence in the process. Know-It-Alls do the reverse: they demonstrate their own intelligence by giving directives and solutions, which gets fast short-term results but teaches people to stop thinking for themselves and simply wait for instructions.

CHALLENGER

- poses hard questions*
- seeds opportunity*
- builds their thinking*

KNOW-IT-ALL

- gives directives*
- dispenses answers*
- stops their thinking*

HOW EACH RESPONDS WHEN A HARD PROBLEM APPEARS

A good challenge, Wiseman writes, plants a seed of possibility in someone's mind and leaves them believing something is achievable that they hadn't previously considered. That belief, not the answer itself, is what builds lasting capability.

WHAT THE AUTHOR WANTS YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Wiseman's instruction: the next time you're tempted to hand someone the answer you already know, replace it with a question that hands them the problem instead, and let them build the capability of solving it themselves.

The Debate Maker

Debate Makers drive sound decisions through rigorous debate before deciding; Decision Makers decide quickly, often alone or within a closed circle.

Debate Makers, Wiseman explains, engage people in a real, structured debate over an important decision before it's made — deliberately pulling in diverse perspectives and letting the tension of genuine disagreement sharpen the thinking. This takes longer than simply deciding, but it builds both a better decision and a deeper organisational understanding of why the decision was made. Decision Makers, by contrast, make the call quickly and efficiently, often relying on a small inner circle or their own judgement, leaving everyone else to execute a decision they were never part of.

DEBATE MAKER	DECISION MAKER
<i>opens real debate</i>	<i>decides quickly, alone</i>
<i>pulls in diverse views</i>	<i>relies on inner circle</i>
<i>builds shared understanding</i>	<i>leaves others out</i>

HOW EACH STYLE REACHES AN IMPORTANT DECISION

People support what they helped debate, even when the final decision doesn't go their way — Wiseman's point is that the debate itself, not just the decision it produces, is what builds ownership and understanding across the organisation.

WHAT THE AUTHOR WANTS YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Wiseman's prescription: before your next important decision, deliberately open it up to structured debate with a genuinely di-

verse set of views, rather than deciding quickly within your usual small circle.

The Investor

Investors give people real ownership of results and back them up when needed; Micromanagers take over execution themselves.

Investors, Wiseman writes, define clear ownership, invest the resources people need to succeed, and then hold them accountable for the result — staying available as a source of support rather than stepping in to do the work themselves. Micromanagers do the opposite: they jump into the details and effectively take over, which might improve one outcome in the short run but teaches people that their own judgement isn't trusted, and that initiative isn't worth taking.

INVESTOR	MICROMANAGER
<i>gives real ownership</i>	<i>takes over execution</i>
<i>invests in success</i>	<i>controls the details</i>
<i>holds people accountable</i>	<i>owns the outcome instead</i>

WHO ACTUALLY HOLDS THE OUTCOME, ONCE WORK IS UNDERWAY

Full ownership, paired with real accountability, is what builds people's capability over time — Wiseman is careful to note this isn't about abandoning people; the Investor stays engaged as a resource, but resists the urge to take the work back.

WHAT THE AUTHOR WANTS YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Wiseman wants you to identify the next task you'd normally take back over yourself, hand full ownership of it to someone else instead, and make yourself available as backup without stepping in.

Becoming a Multiplier

Shifting from Diminisher habits to Multiplier ones starts with a single, deliberate practice, not a wholesale personality change.

Wiseman closes by acknowledging that most leaders are not purely one type or the other — they carry a mix of Multiplier and Diminisher habits, often without full awareness of which is which in any given moment. **The goal isn't to become a different person; it's to notice your own default patterns and deliberately practice the specific discipline you're weakest in.**

She recommends starting small and specific — picking one Diminisher tendency you recognise in yourself, from one of the five chapters, and consciously practising its Multiplier counterpart in a single upcoming interaction, rather than attempting to overhaul your entire leadership style at once.

WHAT THE AUTHOR WANTS YOU TO DO WITH THIS

Wiseman's closing instruction: choose the one Diminisher pattern from the five chapters that you recognise most in yourself, and practise its Multiplier counterpart deliberately in your very next relevant conversation.

QUESTIONS TO THINK ABOUT

- 1** Thinking of two bosses you've had, what specifically did each one do that made you feel either more or less capable?
- 2** Where might you be an Accidental Diminisher — well-intentioned, but still shutting down capability without realising it?
- 3** Do you know each person on your team's native genius — the thing they do so naturally it doesn't feel like effort to them?
- 4** Would you let your most talented person leave for a bigger opportunity, even if it cost you directly?
- 5** Do people around you offer their real, unfinished thinking, or only safe answers they know you'll approve of?
- 6** When was the last time you admitted a mistake in front of your team, before anyone else pointed it out?
- 7** When a hard problem comes up, is your instinct to hand over the answer, or to hand over the question?
- 8** Before your last major decision, who did you genuinely debate it with — and who was left out of that conversation?
- 9** What is one task you're still holding onto that you could hand over as full ownership instead?
- 10** Where do you tend to step in and take over, even when someone else was already capable of finishing the work?

- 11** Of the five Multiplier disciplines, which one is your current weakest, and what would practising it look like this week?
- 12** What is the very next conversation where you could deliberately practise a Multiplier habit instead of your usual default?